THE RAMBAM'S EIGHT CHAPTERS - SHEMONAH PERAKIM

Is Your Solution Becoming the Problem?

The Rambam's Eight Chapters

Sefer: Shemonah Perakim (the Eight Chapters) by the Rambam **Chapter:** The end of Chapter 4, then Managing Polarities **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Tuesday-night series on the Shemonah Perakim, Tuesday 12 March 2024

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review

The Rabbi planned to finish Chapter 4 and then spend the second half applying the middle path to modern life. He reviewed: the healthy soul lives in equilibrium; people sometimes praise extremes such as recklessness; the cure is to go to the opposite extreme for a time and come back; the hasid leans slightly to the side from which it is easier to return; and the Nazir, who abstained for a limited time, brings an offering because he denied himself what God permitted.

Fasting and the prophet Zekhariah

The Rambam brings further support from Zekhariah. After the return from Babylon, the people asked whether they should still weep and fast in the fifth month, Av. The prophet answered: when you fasted these seventy years, was it for Me? Whether you eat or do not eat, you remain the same person. Instead he told them to judge truly and act with kindness. Then came the famous verse: the fasts of the fourth, fifth, seventh and tenth months will become days of joy, "and love truth and peace."

The Rambam explains: **truth** is the perfection of the intellect, and **peace** is the perfection of character, through which peace comes to the world. The Rabbi's point: fasting is fine, but you are the same person fasting. Pursuing truth and peace changes who you are, and that is what lasts.

The misvot keep us in balance

The Rambam then addresses those who copy the ascetic ways of other nations and think it is refinement. The Rabbi said this was clearly aimed at the same ascetic practices discussed last week. The Torah already gives us the misvot that keep us at the middle, or slightly towards the safer side. There is no need to add.

His examples: - **Pleasure.** The Torah forbids certain foods and sets limits on relations, even within marriage, to keep us from being immersed in pleasure. It does not forbid them altogether. - **Generosity.** The gifts to the poor, such as the forgotten sheaf, the corner of the

field and the fallen grapes, together with the Sabbatical year, the Jubilee and sedakah, all train us away from miserliness. Yet the Torah also limits how much one should give away. - **Anger.** The commands against revenge and bearing a grudge, and the duty to help even an enemy load or unload his animal, weaken anger. - **Selfishness.** Returning lost property takes away miserliness. - **Brazenness and over-shyness.** Honouring parents, elders and scholars works against brazenness. But the Torah also says to rebuke your fellow and not to fear any man, so that we do not become too meek. "Sometimes you have to stand up."

So a person who adds oaths and prohibitions, or gives far more charity than the Torah asks, goes to the other extreme. The Rambam then quotes a saying of Hazal in the Yerushalmi, word for word, which the Rabbi said the Rambam loved enough to quote despite his rule against quoting: **"Is it not enough for you what the Torah has forbidden, that you add further prohibitions on yourself?"** For the Rambam, this one line sums up the chapter.

Preventive medicine

Near the end of the chapter the Rambam turns to prevention. Just as a person who feels a cold coming on rests and takes care before it becomes a week in bed, or protects a weak leg before it needs physiotherapy, a whole person should weigh his traits constantly and correct a small drift before it needs strong medicine.

The Rabbi noted that most of us do this once a year, in Elul and on Yom Kippur. In the Rambam's ideal it is daily, perhaps in the morning or at night. No one should imagine he is perfect. The philosophers said it is almost impossible to find someone perfect in all traits, and the prophets said the same: "There is no righteous man on earth who does good and never sins."

The sin of Moshe Rabbenu

The Rambam ends with a famous question: what was Moshe's sin at the waters of Merivah? His answer is simple. Moshe lost his patience: "Listen now, you rebels." The people around him had seen revelation at Sinai and would learn from everything he did. If the prophet of God grew angry, they would conclude that anger was right, and that God was angry with them, which He was not. That is why it says "you did not sanctify Me." It was a Hillul HaShem.

The Rabbi linked this to the Rambam's definition of Hillul HaShem in the Mishneh Torah: the greater the person, the greater the desecration. An ordinary person losing patience once is human. Moshe, in his position, could not.

The chapter closes with a teaching of Hazal on the verse *vesam derekh*. Do not read *vesam*, "he sets a way", but *vesham*, "he evaluates his way." One who weighs his path will see the salvation of God. This is the whole chapter in a phrase.

Managing polarities

In the second half the Rabbi turned to a modern framework, polarity management, using slides that had been shared with him by an educator in London. He said that understanding it and applying it "can honestly change our lives."

He began with the rabbit-duck illusion: one person sees a duck, another sees a rabbit, and each is sure he is right. Both are. A polarity is **"an ongoing problem with two or more correct answers that are interdependent."**

Activity and rest. Run until you are tired, then rest, then run a little further. That is a positive "infinity loop" that spirals upwards. The negative loop is three hours at the gym after months of nothing, aching for days, resting too long, then overdoing it again. The early warnings matter: waking up tired may mean too much activity; skipping a planned workout may mean too much rest. This is the Rambam's preventive medicine in another form.

His central sentence: **"The root of all problems is seeing one polarity as the solution or the other polarity as the problem."** Neither pole alone is the answer. Together they are.

He gave more examples: - **Inclusive and exclusive.** Inclusivity sounds wonderful, but taken alone we can lose our boundaries and identity. Exclusivity alone is not who we want to be either. He applied this to the immigration debate in the run-up to the UK election, where each side tends to take one pole. The wise leader holds both. He stressed he was discussing the principle, not taking a political side. - **Part and whole.** In his experience, many marriage problems come from losing the balance between the couple as one unit and the two individuals within it, either focusing too much on oneself or giving until one feels nothing is coming back. - **Planning and implementing.** Some plan endlessly; others jump in unprepared. The healthy tension between the two produces the best result. - **Support and independence.** Here he made an important point: poles must be named in neutral terms. When a participant offered "negligence" as the opposite of support, he said that is already negative; the neutral opposite is independence. After a job with too much support, the answer is not total independence, but more independence alongside some support. - **National and global interests.** He gave Brexit as an example of the debate being fought between two poles, again saying he was not taking a political position. - **Change and stability.** A traditional community losing its young people swings to radical change, loses its older members, swings back, and declines each time. The positive loop respects tradition while making careful changes.

He ended with a line from the slides: "The test of a first-rate intelligence is the ability to hold two opposed ideas in mind at the same time, and still retain the ability to function."

Homework

He asked everyone to choose one of their own character traits and map it as a polarity for the next class. His example: a former miser who throws it all away and spends everything, then regrets it and becomes a miser again, is in a negative loop. A positive loop is spending on a treat today and holding back for the next while, each according to his means.

After the recording, one participant questioned whether we really can govern our personality as the Rambam assumes. The Rabbi disagreed strongly: the whole purpose of a human being is free will and the ability to change who we are.

Summary

- Fasting does not change who we are; truth and peace do, and so the prophet put them above the fasts.
- The misvot are built to keep us balanced, so adding extra prohibitions is itself an extreme: "Is it not enough what the Torah has forbidden?"
- Preventive medicine for the soul means weighing our traits regularly, ideally every day.
- Moshe's sin was a moment of anger, which in a leader of his stature became a Hillul HaShem.
- In polarity management, problems come from treating one pole as the whole solution; the answer is to hold both and keep moving between them.

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